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Javon Jackson

Tenor saxophonist Javon Jackson was born in Carthage, Missouri on June 16, 1965. He attended the University of Denver and the Berklee College of Music, and cites his time with Art Blakey and Elvin Jones as his significant jazz education. Javon has recorded prolifically as a sideman and now leads his own quartet, recording on the Criss Cross label.

Javon was interviewed at Hamilton College on September 23, 2010 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have saxophonist and composer Javon Jackson with me today, for the Jazz Archive.

JJ: Good to be with you.

MR: Thank you. I'm looking forward to your concert here. But I wanted to start off asking you a little bit about something that I'm guessing is important to you and that is your composing.

JJ: I'm getting more involved with composing, very much involved with it now as the years have gone on. Joining Art Blakey, that was something that he really emphasized for us to do, writing, and it is very important to find your own self and some sense of your individuality through your own writing, so that's very important.

MR: I saw a recent addition to your website and that you're going to do a film score for something in Syracuse?

JJ: Right. In about three weeks. I'm really excited about it. I got an opportunity to write a score for a Hitchcock silent film called "The Lodger." So I finished it up in the summer, and I finally got all the parts ready and sent them out to the musicians and so we have a rehearsal the day before the premiere, and then we do play the music live in front of an audience —

MR: How cool.

JJ: With the film above us, so I'm pretty psyched to get connected to Hitchcock in this fashion.

MR: How do you go about landing a commission like that or whatever you want to call it?

JJ: Well I met the artistic director's wife and told her of my interest in it and my willingness to be a part of writing for a film or TV. It's been something that I've kind of been looking for. And so I got a chance to speak to her husband and they asked me if I'd like to do it and I jumped at it. And so that started in basically February. So it's been a great process, a learning process for me. Traveling and doing it has been unique as well, because I had been writing basically from the piano to sheet music, which nowadays everything is done

to a program. So I'm actually archaic at this point. But I'll get up to speed with the various programs that are available to me on the next project, so I had some help in terms of getting it put into a program and then obviously I needed help to sync the music up with the film.

MR: Ah. I know right where you're at with that. Trying to learn Finale and that kind of stuff.

JJ: Right.

MR: Did you have — not restrictions — but did they have to tell you well here's our budget, here's what we can do as far as musicians and so forth?

JJ: Absolutely. The budget was like ha-ha-ha — but it's their budget that they have every year and obviously with the all the various events that they have going on I was happy to take it and the other musicians were willing to work with me, and for me I would have almost paid a little bit just to do it.

MR: Sure.

JJ: So the opportunity speaks volumes to my chance at something like this. So it's a good learning process for me to go through and then also something to have a little cachet to show the people about my ability in this area.

MR: How is it different from that kind of specific assignment, something that's going to go with a visual as opposed to you're sitting at the piano and you want to write something for your band?

JJ: Well with my band, with the situation with a jazz group, the performance obviously is going to be much more in the moment or more extemporaneous in terms of the presentation, whereas the skeleton, which is the melody, is a small piece of the beginning for the most part, and a small piece at the end, which mirror each other. Whereas in the music in a film, especially with a silent film, the music is continuous. So we have a general theme and then hopefully we can develop that theme in different ways, maybe in a different key or in a different tempo, different meter is what I mean, all these different colors or maybe one instrument plays the melody and later on the melody is played by another instrument. So the melodies are kind of more blown out and flushed out as opposed to in the situation with a small group, I play the melody and then we play a lot off into soloing so also the melody takes its own life along with that individual that you link the character to, so that that character begins to shape the melody by their behavior in the film, in my opinion.

MR: Yeah. Will this music for this film be improvised at all?

JJ: There is improvisation but a lot of it has pretty much been composed —

MR: You scored it.

JJ: And written parts. There's not as much improvisation as I think one would expect from me, it's actually more written and with melodies and supporting themes and supporting

the individuals and the direction in which the story goes. So trying to allow that to be my blueprint.

MR: Whenever I try to write something that doesn't have much improvisation in it, I get discouraged. I write and write and then I time it, and I go "oh, I have 90 seconds so far."

JJ: Well for me I just looked at the scenes. If the scene was a certain amount of minutes it didn't matter because I had to have the music to fit the scene as if that was my framework. So when the scene or when something shifted, then the music in my mind would shift with the story.

MR: So let's talk about Art Blakey and composing. I'm thinking of you taking a tune to Mr. Blakey and why would he like something and not something else?

JJ: Well one thing that was unique about Art Blakey, he didn't dislike anything. He would take any individual's music and make it work for the ensemble. He might have a suggestion or he might have some constructive criticism, but by and large I never saw Art just dismiss a song. He would find a way to rehearse it, we'd play it a couple of times. Now if he liked it it would get played more maybe than someone else's compositions, but I never knew Art — because he really encouraged everyone to write music. So in that respect Art was very supportive. Because he knew for the most part most of us were just embryonic with the writing aspect, being young guys, and some of the older musicians were older, maybe 23, 24, they had a little bit more experience with writing or who just had a better ability so that maybe more of their songs would be played. But everyone that came in the band wasn't Benny Golson or wasn't, in my time, a Donald Brown or a Mulgrew Miller who wrote really strong compositions. But he found a way to incorporate the music in the Messenger songbook at some point — a Wayne Shorter, or some of these other special artists, but Art really was encouraging. And that's something that I think sometimes we all talk about the Jazz Messengers, but we all know it's understated that Art was very, very supportive of young musicians, I mean he made it his whole life's work to support young musicians as they came up and as they developed. Then they left and he got more young musicians and developed them, and the cycle just continued for I'd say the from the mid-fifties until he passed. So he really did a whole lot in terms of nurturing or creating a foundation for this art form.

MR: Do you know if — a lot of those fellows who started out with him did that training — did most of them leave to become leaders themselves or did he tell them, "Look time for you to move on"?

JJ: Well each situation would be different. I think some musicians felt that it was time to leave. I think in some situations he knew when to get another musician out of the nest to say. So every situation was different but we all feel that, at least I can speak for the musicians that I knew, the Freddie Hubbards of the world or the Jackie McLeans or

various other artists, that once they left Art there was a certain learning curve that you go through that you did feel a certain comfort level with how to lead bands or you had some experience. Because you got to watch someone in action. And there's so many things that I — more and more as I become an experienced band leader — I look back to him and say now some of the things that he did make sense, but they didn't make sense before, or as a young person coming up you didn't necessarily agree with it but as the leader somebody has to make the decision. And, as President Obama is finding out, people, no matter what the decision is, there's always going to be someone who doesn't agree with it and there's going to be someone who can work with it. But being a leader we have to delegate and not worry about how people feel about you and more so just to be respected for what you are trying to do, and hopefully that's appreciated.

MR: Can you give me a specific example of something he might have done for taking care of business on the bandstand for instance?

JJ: On the bandstand it wasn't so authoritative as opposed to maybe some general situations. I mean travel decisions had to be made. On the bandstand Art was supportive. Now for example if there was something that he didn't like he wouldn't tell you what to do, but he would say leave that aspect out. For example, one time I was at a part of a show called "feature time" where he would let an artist come down front and play a ballad feature with the rhythm section. So I'm the saxophonist, piano, bass and Art, and I play a ballad. So just joining, sometimes we're working on these figures or working on lines on our own, for phrases. And I had a bit of a habit with playing a phrase, maybe the phrase didn't come out like I wanted, and maybe going back and trying to play the phrase, okay? And a couple of times I think maybe I was doing it in a way that it was noticeable to the audience so he just said, "Listen, you make a mistake, make it loud but move on, you don't have to go back. Turn the mistake into something." So in that way he told me what not to do but he encouraged me and supported me to make the mistake, something that everyone would appreciate anyway and no one is going to notice a mistake unless you basically say oh I'm sorry, I'd better do that one again, which is basically what I said, through the saxophone. So if that gives you an idea of the kind of person that he was, and he was really supportive. And again, I don't ever remember him telling someone what to do, but he would say, "Leave that out," or, "don't do that one again." And obviously the verbiage would be a little different than I'm using now but you get the gist of what I'm trying to say.

MR: Did he have things he would do if he thought you were coasting and not giving your hundred percent?

JJ: Well he would always let everyone know that if you don't give a hundred ten percent, don't come to the stage. At the point that I met Art he was in his late sixties, he always

felt, and he probably felt this for a long time. He said listen, when I play I play as if this could be the last time, because it could. So he never played halfway. It was always full bore. And anyone that played with Art or who watched Art play can attest to that. He was a person that always gave every bit of what he had at that moment into the music. And I think of him as an example that allowed us all to understand okay we can't coast. So I wouldn't say that there was ever anyone coasting, and he would always find a way to get the musicians to work with each other, and sometimes outplay each other, which again is a testament to a leader, to a great coach, to get his players to in some ways compete, but really they're creating. So in that way Art really knew how to push buttons.

MR: I saw him in his band, it must have been in '76 or something at the Saratoga Jazz Festival, and I was just astounded at the energy and the enthusiasm. And I remember I think every song that then ended, when it was over, wham.

JJ: Right. He had the last word.

MR: It was like he couldn't resist.

JJ: He had the last word.

MR: And you've had this experience with, fortunately, catching him and Elvin Jones right at the end of their careers. That's fortunate I guess.

JJ: Well yeah, fortunate for me. Also just the way my life worked out, that towards the end of their careers and their lives and so it just signals that there was a kind of changing of the era, with the passing of these musicians. Elvin was a very, very special person, much in the way of Art, very supportive, very loving, of the diaspora in general. Very, I mean in love with jazz music is what I'm saying, just in love with the musicians. I mean obviously when he spoke of John Coltrane there was a reverence, when he spoke of Charlie Parker, when he spoke of Billie Holiday, when he spoke of his friends, in addition to his brothers, but he just had a loving feeling and the utmost responsibility for the music that he was trying to play. And so I think that's something that Art and Elvin had in common, that they really never shortchanged anyone. No one can ever say they went to see Elvin Jones or Art Blakey and they got shortchanged. It's impossible. You always got your money's worth.

MR: That's true. I remember seeing him in a club once and I thought he was fearsome. I mean you say he was a loving person on stage, but I mean he would sweat and you would see his teeth and you said man, this man is —

JJ: Well that was the look of his presentation. And so I'm not saying that he wasn't very dynamic and very strong, but I mean in a conversation with Elvin, he was so articulate and so specific in his thoughts about the music and his ideas, and his feelings towards the musicians. And so that's what I mean in terms of a very loving appreciation for him to have been able to have played the drums with these different artists. But obviously on

stage he was a killer, to coin a phrase. But I mean he absolutely was. There was nothing about him that was — it was loving but it still had a certain energy and passion that you know, Art was called "The Volcano" by Dizzy and Elvin was nicknamed "Thunder."

MR: Okay.

JJ: So that probably speaks to what you're talking about.

MR: Yeah. Probably got surrounded there. Just to go back to the composing for a bit, you have a tune that you wrote called "Mr. Jones" I believe. And was there a reason that you chose, I think it's either 6/8 or 3/4 groove. Is there a reason for that?

JJ: Well I love Elvin's playing on 3/4. If you listen to him on recordings with John, there's one that they do called "Spiritual," which is in C minor. So really that feeling of what we're playing is kind of loosely, in my humble ability, to try to come from that spirit or the energy that John Coltrane played from. "Live at the Vanguard" is our spiritual, is our spirit, which as a group is from that. So it is my appreciation for Elvin's ability to play in 3/4.

MR: Okay. And there was one more I wanted to ask you about, "Mr. Taylor."

JJ: Um hum.

MR: Is that for Cecil Taylor?

JJ: No. I know Cecil. It was written for a gentleman that I've known for quite some time, he's a very, very good friend of mine and he's just an avid jazz fan in general but he's kind of my groupie, he's followed me all over the world and I appreciate being around him. He's got a great spirit about him and he's a clinical psychologist so he just has so much information and wealth of things to share, and so that was written out of my relationship with him.

MR: Oh. Well that's a nice tribute to somebody, to have a tune.

JJ: Yeah. That's great jazz. I'm sure he'll be happy to see that someone asked about him.

MR: Yeah. And one thing that caught my ear about that tune, that I enjoyed, was the unison piano and tenor on the melody.

JJ: Right. Eric Reed is so special, I think I might have mentioned if he wanted to he could play the melody with me, or maybe in the rehearsal, we did a brief rehearsal, he just said, "Oh I want to play the melody with you." And so I was really happy to have Eric. I have known him for quite some time and I have a lot of respect for his abilities as a musician and I'm very, very honored to have him on the CD.

MR: Um hum. It's always good to have something that makes your quartet, how do you orchestrate for a quartet you know, and just those little things, oh, let's play unison here.

JJ: Right.

MR: It may not seem like a big thing, but to me I like it.

JJ: Absolutely. It helps the arrangement, the little subtleties, like you say that you mentioned that you noticed, those are things that help to make it more individual, the presentation, or separate. Because there's so much material that you have an opportunity to listen to, and so many recordings nowadays, with everyone having the ability basically to make their own music. So you have to try to find, at some point, some way to stand out, not that it's better but just that it could be somewhat unique or different from all the various pieces of music that come out today.

MR: Let me ask, when you were let's say 15 or 16, you are playing the saxophone, you had a supportive family environment as far as music. Did you have aspirations at that age to be a professional musician?

JJ: Right. Absolutely. By that time in my mind I was already going to be a Jazz Messenger.

MR: Really?

JJ: Yeah. My father and mother had a vast music collection. So I heard everything from the OJ's to the Temptations to Sly and the Family Stone to Miles Davis, Carlos Santana, John Coltrane, Ahmad Jamal, Les McCann and Eddie Harris, so all that music, which kind of shocked me, because when I got to college, a lot of the music that was just in my house, a lot of musicians hadn't heard of it. But my father, a big jazz saxophonist lover, and particularly Gene Ammons. So I was about 13 and into the music, and again, a lot of it started with him. For example, I'd be upstairs practicing and he'd come upstairs and say, "Hey, you think you could play this?" and he'd give me something, and it's be Gene Ammons. So he was a guy that kind of initiated me to try to learn solos or gets lines from solos and things like that. It was him. My father. Anyway, Sonny Stitt comes to town two or three years later and he takes me to see Sonny Stitt. And I got to meet him and I got to watch him, and when I left the club there was no doubt in my mind that I was going to be a jazz saxophonist. I was going to be a professional saxophonist that traveled all over the world and makes records, as early as 14. I really believe, yeah, that was my firm, strong belief of what I was hearing. So after that it was just a matter of starting to take private lessons and meeting musicians who could get me closer to Art Blakey. My father had one of his recordings where he talks on the back, the Clifford Brown recording, and he talks on the back about having young musicians and when they get too old I'll get some more, and then three or four years later, out burst this young man named Wynton Marsalis playing with Art and then obviously it really strengthened my desire to be a Jazz Messenger.

MR: The decision to go to Berklee, I don't know if at the time you would have thought this, what was the goal?

JJ: The goal was to be with Art Blakey. I was told to go to Berklee.

MR: Okay.

JJ: I was in McDonald's All American Band, a high school all-American band, which takes two students — I don't know if it exists anymore — but it takes two students from each state in the United States. I represented Colorado, me and another person, and Delfayo Marsalis represented Louisiana. Well when I met him, the first thing I said was, "I want to meet your brother." We were in New York doing the Macy's Day parade. And so I remember afterwards, and the first thing I go up to him and I said, "I want to play with Art Blakey, I want to play with you, I want to" — . So he said, "Well listen, next time I come to Denver I'll give you a call." And I gave him my phone number and let's say it was ten months later, he comes to Denver with Wynton Marsalis and I'm sitting on my bed waiting for the phone to ring and about 11 or 12 o'clock the phone rings and it's Branford. And I had so much respect for him, because I know how it is now and when people ask things of you, of your time, you're moving so quickly and it's so hard when you're getting in and out of hotels and things, for him to follow through. And Branford is not that much older than me so if I was 18 or 19, he was 23 or 24. For him to make that telephone call back to me. And he came over to the house and he listened, we hung out and I said, "I want to play with Art Blakey." And he says, "Well okay, you've got to get your fingers together. I want you to go to Berklee and you should go to Berklee and study with Billy Pierce." And Delfayo had just enrolled, he had just started his freshman year at Berklee, this was right after the McDonald's period, and I was going to a college in Denver, DU, and so I did just what he told me. I transferred, I got things together, I told my parents what he felt, Javon's got a little talent here and that kind of thing, and so then I went right to Berklee. So it was all part of that plan. And so again, we all know these things, when he want something we listen to the people we think can get us there. So I went right to Berklee and I was there for a couple of years and in my goal to meet Billy I met Donald Brown who is a magnificent pianist, but he was teaching there and he was a current member of the Messengers. And I became very closely in his company. I followed him everywhere. I would go see him places play, I would go sit in with him, I'd watch him and talk to him about the music, and so I initially got my opportunity to sit in because of Donald Brown. So I'm a firm believer in goals. I just believe when you put it out there and you speak it out or put it out there to the world, you speak it into existence. And so it just all pretty much happened, very quickly though, in that kind of motion.

MR: Really interesting. And it makes me think about earlier you had said, referring to Art Blakey and Elvin Jones, when they passed that there was a short of a signal to shift in jazz some, but you found a mentor and hung with that guy and it led to what you were hoping for. I mean the mentorship thing is not what it used to be, at least in talking to these fellows from the thirties and the forties it seems like.

JJ: Well you know, every era says that the next era isn't like their era.

MR: Yeah, that's true.

JJ: So I'm starting to look at things in a way that, when I talk to my son I seem old. You see what I mean? So each generation says I don't know how you guys are going to make it. It wasn't like that in my day. And they find a way to make it. So I think a lot of times, no disrespect to any generation, but I think we fabricate things in a way to make it seem like it was so much better when we grew up, when it was just that way when we grew up. It doesn't make it better, it was the way it was. So I was fortunate to have opportunities to mentor with Art, to mentor with Elvin, but I still say there's a lot of great musicians from the next era that are still available. Ron Carter is still here. Wynton Marsalis has taken on that level of availability to mentor. He's not the same age, but, and Wayne Shorter is still here. You've got all these magnificent artists that are still available. Now in some ways you've got to work a little harder to find them, but no one is untouchable. I mean if you really want to get to — I believe it — if I really wanted to get to President Obama, I could get a letter to him. I mean I just don't think that anything is that out of reach. I don't believe it. You know, the fact that we're talking about him as a president.

MR: There you go.

JJ: We could all have agreed twenty years ago it would never have happened. So there's always something available. So the mentorship is different, but I think it's still available. When musicians say for example, we don't have the clubs like there were forty years ago. No, but look at all the various opportunities that are in the various schools and curriculums. So it seems like the clubs — there's been a shift. I'm not going to say it's better or worse, it's different. And so each individual has to make it work for him or her as opposed to saying well I wish it was better this way. Well that doesn't make any sense to say that. You just have to make it work for you. This is the way it is. Sure it'd be great to have had ten to fifteen clubs in New York like there were thirty, forty years ago. Well there's not. There's only five or six major clubs, so get in the mix and be part of those, or whatever it takes to create a sense where you can be viable. The concert I'm doing tomorrow night is part of a series of events that I'm doing partnered with mid-Atlantic Arts, and they are providing something to make this thing happen. So there's a lot of things happening, in some ways many more opportunities now available to create oneself. Like you say, I still came from an era where just the tip in of working with somebody, getting an apprenticeship, sure, I happen to think that is a better way than maybe some of the situations that are coming up now. I feel like a lot of musicians aren't getting the firsthand experience that I got. So when I went to Art Blakey and said, "Well could I talk to you about Thelonious Monk" it wasn't secondhand information. So in that way, yes, but there's still some musicians that are here today that can tell you about Thelonious Monk or that can tell you about Art Blakey or can tell you about Charlie Parker. So there

is becoming less and less of them but even still there is going to be a conduit from that person to the next person to the next person and so that's the way you have to work it. I mean everyone doesn't know Frank Sinatra, but there's someone who knew him or knew — I met a woman the other night, I was in Monterey at the jazz festival — I met Louis Jordan's widow.

MR: Wow.

JJ: And I met her through another person, but I said wow. And so I'm quizzing her and I'm talking to her and I'm saying wow. Because this person was Sonny Rollins' first influence, was Louis Jordan, told to me by Sonny. So it just shows you that all this information is still available to us and we have the music. So I mean sure there's pros and cons everywhere. There's organic and there's this and that, but everyone has to work it out for themselves, to what degree that they want to go out for themselves and try to seek it. Because I still believe these opportunities are very much here.

MR: Have you ever had to work a — let's say from the time you went to Berklee — have you ever had to work a non-music job?

JJ: No. [sound of knock on wood]. No I never have. I'll tell you, the only thing I would do, in the summers I would work in Denver for Frontier Airlines and I worked this job because I wanted to buy a saxophone. So I loaded planes and loaded luggage and unloaded luggage for I think two summers. And then I was able to buy, maybe the saxophone I have now or maybe the saxophone prior to it. So yeah, in that respect, other than working a little bit at Tower Records in Boston at Berklee to have some extra cash, I've been fortunate that the career has been good to me, that there's never had to be any other type of job than just playing the saxophone, or in this business we know as music.

MR: If you look at your — you're doing your income taxes at the end of the year or whenever, can you get a sense of how your income, as a total, how is it broke up between live gigs, some teaching, recording, whatever.

JJ: For me I would say heavy on the performance. But there's a lot of school things that are involved in there. Recordings sure, that's in there too. But I'd say performing would be strong but we do a lot of, well I do a lot of, well I say we I'm speaking for the band, we do a lot of performing arts centers or like the situation tomorrow. So that would be, I don't know, 70/30. Because there's always usually an educational component like we are doing now with you. So that aspect is there. That was a good question. I would say, again, there's a lot of involvement with colleges and things like that, or educational situations. So I would say, yeah, thinking about it, it's probably say 70/30 but it may be 65/35, because it always seems to be some kind of component. But in the summer then a lot of them are just festivals because there's no school in session. So I would say, and we

do a lot of work in the summer, touring Japan or touring Europe or touring in the States, which wouldn't have any kind of educational component. So maybe 70/30.

MR: The record business, LPs, CDs, etc. has changed an awful lot. Do you have a decent relationship with a label now?

JJ: Well I do, with Palmetto, I enjoy them very much and I work very, very hard. It does seem that a lot of musicians have gone the route of recording for themselves and investing in their career in that way, and I'm all for it. I think it's for those, again, each situation is different for each individual, and also it's the availability to the funds to make that happen. Because once you make the recording, hopefully you'd like someone to get it to the radio station and then you've got to pay for someone to distribute it, and you've got to pay for it to be made, and then those kinds of things. And so the fees, outside just the recording, still can be moderate. Because I know a bunch of musicians that do it and are very successful with it. So it's one way of doing things.

MR: Are there issues in the business of music, as far as getting gigs and so forth, that are non-musical, generational, racial, man/woman, anything like that. Does that come into play as far as you know?

JJ: Well, I look at it like this. You get on the phone, you make a phone call to a club, you mention to the club owner, "I'd like to work your venue." And either they're available or they're not. Now available to you or they're not. Now I know a lot of people, musicians that I know, will tell you well you can't do it on your own and you can't call clubs because they don't want to talk to musicians, and I have found that to be the absolute nontruth. The festivals that we just played, I booked them, I have a rider, I have a contract, I do all that kind of stuff. I found that I was not, at the time, viable enough to make management relevant for me. So I felt that I could do better by selling myself myself. And after you get over the initial shock of making the first phone call, which to this day I have never received a no. I have never called a club owner or head of a festival and received a no. Because I don't look at it as a no. All it means is for this year there is no room. Then you call back the next year. There may be no room. And then the next year [finger snaps] you get the gig. So I never look at it as no, it just means not right now, which is that's what it means. And so you never take it — the tough thing is to sell yourself and to have someone tell you no, and no take it personally. Because it's not personal. The bottom line is are you viable enough to help this presenter, i.e. club owner, make the amount of money that you're asking for so that it's a win-win for him and you. So if it's not then you have to bring him a product that will help him help you. That's the way I look at it. So it's the same as anybody in any other profession. And I think what happens with the musician, it's tough. Because you have this artistic property where we practice all day and now I've got to sell myself and I've been practicing and I've got this

and I've got this to offer, and who is this guy to tell me that he doesn't like me and my value is this and that. That's when you make it personal. But the business aspect of it is, guess what, this is what it is. Case in point: you called my house. You said, "Javon, I'd like to have you come and speak to me about your life and your career." And we spoke about the price. I said, "Oh man, I don't know if I want to do that" and I hung up the phone. And when I hung up the phone I thought about and I said you know what? If I don't sit down and give reflection of my career or sit down and articulate myself to someone, how is anyone going to know about me? So if I really want success I just walked the other way from success. So I called you back and I said, "You know what? I want the opportunity." Because if it was good enough for Joe Williams, it's good enough for Javon Jackson. But the musician is always weighing these situations where we feel we're not being respected or we're not getting what we deserve. And guess what? Nobody gets what they deserve. That's why we negotiate. And some people don't understand that. Negotiation means you don't get what you want. If you got what you want there would be no negotiation.

MR: But you can get something, you know, and hopefully it's good for you.

JJ: My mother always taught me — God rest her soul — if you can get a bowl of lemonade what do you do — a bowl of lemons what do you do? You make lemonade. So there's always a positive out of a negative. But again, you really have to work at it. You really have to be willing to take that chance. In other words, Branford doesn't negotiate for himself. He has management. But I cannot say well because Branford is doing it that way it has to work that way for me. It doesn't work that way for me. But guess what, you can still be happy. I'm making a lot of great relationships and nurturing relationships and building relationships that will last me twenty, thirty years. So I don't have to feel upset. And if someone says they're not interested, it's not personal. All it lets me know is okay guess what, I need to retool, rethink my plan, and come back to the drawing board with something that can be accessible. Now some people say oh I don't want to do that, well that's okay. But it's still down to what are you offering? So if you make ten phone calls and nobody gives you a gig, that means maybe you've got to rethink your presentation. If, but again, you have some people that just want to practice and play their art and don't want to go through this aspect of getting on the phone and having to go through a lot of the negotiation and conversation that has nothing to do with music. At one point I felt like that too but you know I have a family to provide for. I have a mortgage. So that starts to become part of the conversation. Sure I want to be able to treat the music the same way I did when I was thirteen, but guess what, when I was thirteen I didn't have any responsibilities. So I try to keep that naïveté on stage but the bottom line is it is a business and it is a medium of exchange. You are giving something to receive something. And so

you have to be able to involve yourself in the other aspects. And whether you are doing it yourself or if someone is doing it for you, you are still entering into what we call business.

MR: Have you had potential managers or club owners who would say to you, well if you only did more, you know, organ trio type stuff or if you had a little more, put some reggae into your act, or tried to insert musical decisions for you?

JJ: I've never had a club owner tell me a musical prowess such as that, but I've had club owners asking is there a way that we could beef up the lineup. Now, the first gig I ever had in my life, in New York as a leader was at the Village Vanguard. I went up to the owner, Lorraine Gordon, and said, "I'd like to work the Vanguard." And she said, "Well listen, who's going to be in your band?" I said, "Well let me make some phone calls." Well I knew Ron Carter, not as well as I know him now but I knew him to a point that I felt comfortable with asking him if he'd support me. I called Kenny Barron and I called Louis Nash. She didn't tell me that, but intuitively I felt if I got these names she will give me a week. I went back and I said, "I've got Kenny Barron, Ron Carter and Louis Nash." She gave me a week. That was a lot a pressure, and I learned a lot though. But the point of it is is if you know you're going to play Carnegie Hall, you've got to try to fill Carnegie Hall up, right? So you have to have, and I do have this, I don't know what you'd say, a high end nature. And so my first record I called Elvin, and he did it. So I have always felt that, not that there's a level, but I've never been too nervous to call anybody. So the fact that I have to call these clubs and try to get a performance opportunity for myself, it's not that big of a deal. I've never had a problem with that.

MR: I think that's really interesting in that sometimes when you see a new artist and you see the cast of supporting characters in it, like wow, I always thought that that probably came from the record company. Like you need to have this to help sell your first.

JJ: More times than not it does. More times than not it does. But for me, again, no disrespect to Ron, no disrespect to Les McCann, no disrespect to Kenny Barron or Freddie Hubbard, but I started with Art Blakey. If I'm sitting with Art Blakey and he's talking about Charlie Parker and Sarah Vaughan, Thelonious Monk, John Coltrane, Miles Davis, those were his friends, Bud Powell, so that gave me the confidence because that was an American Express card. When I told people I was with Art Blakey I'd be right in. So I did have a little bit more of a caveat but I think that gave me confidence. As Art Blakey said, no one can stop you but you. And he would always say things like, "Don't be a chicken and scratch for it, be a man and ask for it." So if you want something you've got to reach out for it. And even if Mr. Carter said no, it wouldn't be personal. Again, one of the greatest books I've ever read in my life is called *The Four Agreements* and it's four agreements. And the agreements are: always do your best, don't take things personal, be

impeccable with your word, and don't assume. And I found that not taking anything personal, although it seems like it's a hard concept, nothing is personal. If you got up right now and said I hate the way this interview is going and I hate the way this is working out, we're done, you're out of here. That's not my issue. That's something that you felt, that I can't go inside of your mind to figure out. So it's not personal. It was your choice. So it's a hard concept, and it's taken me years to really wrap myself around things, everyone makes choices that, at the end of the day, are their own personal choices, that have nothing to do with anybody else. That's just what I believe. And so we all make a choice about whether we want success, about whether we want this, and with this and that, and then that choice we make propels us to do the work that we're going to do. So if I want to start playing in the New York Symphony tomorrow, obviously it's going to be a lot of arduous work, but also I've got to meet the people in that area, and I might have to play in the Syracuse Symphony on my way to the New York Symphony or I may never get to the New York Symphony. But the point of it is we are trying to work toward that point and you set a goal for yourself. And I just feel at the end of the day we are all getting what we ask for.

MR: Well I have a feeling your students — you do some work at Purchase?

JJ: I don't do any teaching. I taught at Purchase for four or five years, and you know what? I'm very close to Ron Carter and he said, "You travel a lot." I said, "Yeah." He said, "Well if you can't be there consistently, stop teaching." And I think he's right.

MR: I think he is too. I've often wondered how the musicians who are playing as much as you are manage to do that with any consistency.

JJ: It's a tender balance, because the students come because you're international. But then, that means you have to become local to accommodate students that are coming there, because you're international. And for me, I felt badly after Ron made me look at it that certain way when I was traveling all the time and when I would come back I'm trying to catch a guy up in one week, three weeks worth of stuff. And he wasn't getting that steady development that he deserved. And for me it was just hard to juggle. You've got family and you're trying to travel and then when you're home you're away from home with school, so I just had to make a decision. And then also I did it for me. I didn't feel that I could consistently develop, I just felt my energy was split. I mean if I was at school two days a week or sometimes almost three days a week and I was there eight hours or so, when I got home it was hard for me to get that energy up and put time in for Javon and the saxophone and the music that I needed to do. So I just kind of just made a choice.

MR: Is it hard maintaining a family life with the travel you do?

JJ: I would say normally it is hard, but in my situation, again, I'm unique because my wife has known me since I was twelve years old, we grew up together, we're the same age, so

she's always seen me with a saxophone. So it's not anything — now she had to get used to living with a saxophonist and the quirkiness of a jazz musician, but she never — she's always seen me with a saxophone so that's something that everyone that knows me, that knows us, says oh yeah, Javon has been playing the saxophone forever. So you still playing, yeah, you still playing the saxophone? Yeah. So that's pretty constant, but then I have someone who is my partner who has been willing to sacrifice. Because in a relationship, when someone is doing really well or successful, at some point someone has to sacrifice for the sake of the family. And obviously when I get home from touring or whatever, I make what sacrifices I can to be there to help play catch-up to support that family. Because that's a very important component to my maturity, is family life, and development as an artist, absolutely, is having a family, having them grounded, it creates and promotes humility. Because when you come home from that long tour in Japan, they want you to go down the street and get some more milk. So you need those kinds of things that are very grounding. Or, who's going to wash the clothes this week? Or who's going to sweep the floor? I mean general things. Sometimes we have someone do it. Sometimes we do it. So I appreciate those things that keep me humble.

MR: Is it a challenge to keep a working trio behind you, a consistent group of musicians?

JJ: It can be, to a point, but what I feel, if you share with these musicians what you're trying to do and also if you give enough lead time, if you're booking in March and now we're in September, there's enough lead time to get to a point, the musicians that you want, and sometimes you can't. But again, that's what I learned from Art Blakey. No one monkey stops the show. So you should be able to — see now all these things about Art are coming back to me now. You should be able to get someone else and plug them in and you should still be able to present what it is that you would like to present. You should feel like, oh man I don't have my man on drums, I'm not going to be able to play what I want to play. You see what I mean? You should still be able to present what you want to present. Obviously if you can get a strong nucleus of guys and you can work, but the point of it too is do you have enough work to be able to keep these guys committed to you? I mean you almost have to be on the road all the time which is very difficult. And I know some musicians who stay on the road all the time. And when you're on the road all the time you can get that commitment because there's a volume and you're able to pay musicians a consistent salary. But if you don't have the consistent salary and all of a sudden something pops up well they're already committed to something else, they've got to work, and I don't know that I've been that kind of artist that's getting to the point now, I'm usually doing things a couple, two times a month at least, but what about the other two weeks, when they've got to feed themselves and the other business things that go along with that. So you have to respect anybody that's getting work and hopefully you

can begin to start booking yourself far enough in advance where you can get the musicians, the ones you want to be available for you.

MR: Um hum. Occasionally I'll have a student ask me what I'm thinking about when I improvise. And I usually have a sort of hard time actually answering the question.

JJ: Why?

MR: Because I think I'm fairly much chord oriented. I'm thinking about what chord I'm playing at the same time I'm thinking about trying to create a nice melody over the top of it. But if they're not that familiar with chord structure yet, I'm not sure what to say to them.

JJ: Well you're right, you have to have some understanding of harmonically what's going on. But I will say you try to learn all of these various techniques and your phrases that you're learning and themes, and then hopefully you can go on stage with the clean slate. And then you can just create based on what is provided to you by your musical environment at that particular time. So the pianist is feeding you something, the bass player is feeding you something, and the drummer is feeding you something, and I'm, hopefully, having a conversation with these individuals as well, and obviously we all think the way we think. So in that way you start to build your themes, based on those ideas that are being, they're coming to you from that which you already know and that which you are hopefully being willing to accept or be a part of, that's going on around you. But obviously it starts with vocabulary. So it's like a person wants to speak English. Well you can't speak English unless you know the A-B-C's, unless you know how sentences are put together. So there has to be a certain amount of study before you can involve yourself. So I would say to a person just start learning the language. Once you start learning the language then you will be able to converse. But you can't converse until you know the words. And every music or every language has certain things that go into the music. If I wanted to wake up tomorrow and be a rapper, there's certain things that go with that diaspora that I have to study so that I will feel or be welcomed in as part of the clique. I hear people say well I don't want to learn any of the things in the past because it's going to hinder me. I don't see how. It doesn't hinder a doctor when he studies the history of music, I mean the history of medicine, to be a doctor. Nobody wants to go to a doctor that's never studied any medicine. If you go to a doctor that says well I'm just doing my own thing, I'm not really going to use the history of medicine, nobody would go to that doctor. But all of a sudden when it comes to music, oh man, I'm going to do my own thing. Well you're going to do your own thing, but it's always going to come based on something, unless you're just a hermit in the woods, and then all of a sudden you're going to behave like an animal. Everybody has to cling, I feel, to something, to have a foundation. You've got to come from something. I mean we're all born and we all

learn from somebody how we do what we do. Nobody just took a baby and just left them there, they wouldn't make it. You've got to have some kind of development, so you've got to at some point recognize the techniques and use some part of the technique whether you want to come from the technique of Charlie Parker or you want to use the technique of Lester Young or you want to use the techniques used by Ornette Coleman or John Coltrane or Sun Ra or somebody. But you've got to pull from somewhere.

MR: Probably someone has asked you in the past about your grounding, of those artists. Who do you feel you sort of came out of?

JJ: Well I like to say I steal from everybody. I mean well the original obviously would be Charlie Parker, because someone said, that's where you start. My father was giving me Gene Ammons and Sonny Stitt records so I was listening to that, then came Charlie Parker, then someone said well you need to listen to Dexter Gordon, then I went to see him, then somebody said well okay now you've got to check out a guy named Sonny Rollins. Okay you've got Sonny Rollins, okay, what about Lucky Thompson. Okay, what about Coleman Hawkins. Then you're all over the place. Then after a while Joe Henderson comes along for me, which was a biggie for me. Then all of a sudden I find a guy named Eddie Harris, and so I started listening to him. Well then all of a sudden you say well let's move to the trumpet. And then you hear a guy named Freddie Hubbard. Then you listen to the trombone and you've got J.J. Johnson. Well let's go to the bass, you've got Paul Chambers. And I've learned things from all those musicians. I didn't even mention Miles, how much I learned from him. So there's so much that's available to us. You just listen, and if you enjoy it you try to figure it out a little bit and see what you can use from it and at the same point, as you become an older person, you will find your own way of delivering it. Some people can do it quicker than others. Some people are able to get to it at 19 or 20. But sometimes you have to live a long time, or live a while before you can play something that, you know what, I'm going to play this, this is what I want to play. And you feel comfortable with doing that, and you feel good about it, as opposed to man, I did that but Coltrane wouldn't have done that. You see when you get to a certain age and confidence level you're okay with the fact that Coltrane did it this way and I'm going to do it my way, because we're both, at the end of the day, doing the same thing, we're trying to just enjoy ourselves. But it takes a period, for some, of development. It took me a period, longer probably than others, where I really felt like, you know, this is the way Javon feels about it and I didn't feel like I had to be just like Joe Henderson where there was a period where I really was — I won't say obsessed because I didn't stalk him — but I really was listening to all his recordings and then after a while it started to be to a point where everybody would say oh man he sounds like Joe Henderson. Well it got to a point where it just wasn't flattering anymore. It used to be

flattering, but it got to a point, it didn't hurt my feelings but at a certain point where I said wow, there's other things in there than just Joe Henderson. But for whatever reason, people heard that and you still, again, you just keep building and try to go through the wall. And after a while you let some other influences come into my life and the fact of the matter was there was a lot of Joe Henderson paid attention to by me. And so once I started letting some other things seep through, some other styles, some other ideas, then it started to dilute itself a little bit. It's still there, but it diluted itself.

MR: Are there any artists — I'm not sure how to phrase this — that got to a point with their music that you didn't like it anymore? I'll use an example. When I was younger I didn't know who John Coltrane was yet, when I was in junior high, and someone said, "Well you better listen to John Coltrane" and I went and bought "Om." And my first exposure to John Coltrane was, wow, I could not handle that. Has there been an artist that you admired that kept progressing to the point where he's lost me.

JJ: No. No. I just appreciate the fact that that person or artist is still trying to push the envelope and is still trying to find something different or another facet of their creative nature. So right, Coltrane in '57 is very different than '66, but it's still Coltrane. So I appreciate the ride. I really do. So I don't know, I get a lot of people who are going well Wayne Shorter sure doesn't sound like he did in 1961. He's not supposed to. That's like me saying well man, some of your high school friends say well you don't look like you did when you were 17, well you're not supposed to. You would like to maybe or maybe not. But that's the way this thing is, it's different. And so these trees, they look different every year. The dogs, as they age, they look different. That's what this thing is. We're trying to evolve. And I think a lot of times we have trouble because we're not trying to evolve. We're trying to stay in that place as a listener maybe. But that creative person is trying to move on. But I think if you listen real hard you can still find some of the things, some of that quality that you like in the other person, that's still there. You might have to search a little harder, and you might have to work a little harder. But it's probably still there. Again it's an evolution. So I can't think of any artists that I liked and all of a sudden just didn't like. Now there could be artists that maybe over time they have grown on me, which is the other way. Maybe someone at one point I didn't necessarily understand and now I appreciate. Probably somebody like Led Zeppelin for example. I appreciate them now more. Because I don't listen to it from a perspective of [finger snaps]. I'm not looking for them to swing. I'm trying to appreciate it from their perspective. See when I was younger I was a jazz snob, where everything to me had to funnel itself at some point from one-two-one-two-three-four. So now I'm understanding that okay, Santana loves what we do but it doesn't necessarily follow from the hi-hat on two and four and the bass drum on four beats. You know what I mean? You have to be

able to appreciate that for what it is. I can't go into an Italian restaurant and say man this doesn't taste like soul food. It's not supposed to. And so I think as I've gotten older I've been able to — and I'm still a young man but I'm getting to a point where everybody has all these things to offer. There was a period where I said you know what? I want to play some of the music that influenced me. So you hear me doing [sings] Wake up everybody/no more sleep. So I'm doing that kind of music, where before, when I just left Art and I joined Blue Note Records I probably wouldn't have recorded any of that, or maybe now I'm doing a Marvin Gaye tune or a Stevie Wonder song. As far as I'm concerned, that's open game for me. Now I've got good friends who would say no way. And guess what? That's why these different people are able to come and exist and that's why we have all this wonderful music, because no one thinks the same. Everyone's got a different way of approaching it, and everybody's got a different wrinkle to put in it. And I've got good friends who do have no inclination or would never record a Stevie Wonder song. And I respect them for that. But for me, I feel that I can grow by doing some different things. It helps me become better. Now they might say well if you stay down this way you will become better. But for me, my nature is to search and to look for some different things, as they probably say they are too. So again, it's respecting everyone and what they try to do. Because we're all, at the end of the day, we're all trying to be better.

MR: It takes every kind of people, right?

JJ: It takes every kind of person and I really believe everyone is doing the best they can. And once they try to do better they will. But a person that's the worst person in the world, believe it or not, that's just the best he can do. So hopefully he'll be inspired to do better. So I think at that level it's very basic.

MR: Are you a player who — I guess I'm going back to this thinking and improvisation — do you think scales and modes and that kind of thing while you're playing?

JJ: Well I'd say it's a combination maybe. Obviously you think shapes, where the shape is a sound. So the sound could have a certain harmonic element to it, obviously, but if you're phrasing and shaping, then the harmony is going to come in. So we all at some point begin to play some structure or some sense of the harmony, when we start talking about real creative music and not necessarily jam band type of music or something like that, or pop music, where there's a rhythm that's articulated and rearticulated and it's focused. But when you start to build, yeah, I would think that at some point I'm going to think of a shape. And the shape might take the form of a major triad or is might take the shape of a dominant seventh, or you start to build these themes. And these themes have some kind of harmonic connection. And if you hear a person do it over and over, then you know. Because they've developed something. That's when you know that they've developed it, because they can get to it more than one time. It's not random. If you hear Coltrane do a

succession of records that go to certain themes it lets you know he's figured out a certain type of a system, which is what we all do. When we get up in the morning we learn a system. We have a system, if we're successful, that works best. We don't get up, make the bed, go downstairs and eat, then go back and brush our teeth and then go back downstairs and then go back up and get dressed. You know there's a system. And the ones that have that system, those are the ones that seem to excel. And so there's definitely a system with improvisation but I do feel that you have the themes, you have the shapes, and then you have this willingness to create, whether it's beauty, whether it's a more forceful delivery. All these things play a part in the presentation of a solo.

MR: What constitutes a wrong note for you?

JJ: There is no wrong note. As Art Blakey taught me. Way back when I told you Art Blakey told me if you make a mistake, make it loud.

MR: Okay.

JJ: Yeah, so there is no mistake. We have trained ourself that if we have a C seven and you play a C sharp, that's a wrong note. It's where it's going. Where is the C sharp going. Where are you leading it to. So if you have a C seven and you play a C sharp this means it's a diminished chord.

MR: But if you let it sit there

JJ: So it doesn't make a mistake. If you want it to sit there, that's your choice.

MR: But you are choosing to play that note and have it do whatever.

JJ: If you have a G and you have a G on top, that's an octave. That's the son and another being if you want to look at it like that. If you have a G and you have a D, that's the son and dad. Or if you have the G and the B you have the son and his brothers and sisters. If you have the G and the A, that's the ninth, those are your cousins. If you have a G and a G sharp, it's your next door neighbor. So you're never that far away.

MR: Well said.

JJ: That's the way I look at it.

MR: This has been really terrific. You know and I'm thinking you're going to meet some students later on and I know that there are students here who want to be where you are. And I'm wondering if you — you're obviously very goal oriented — what's your goal for the next number of years and do you have other places that you want to get to?

JJ: Sure. I have a goal where I want to be much more, believe it or not, on tour with me and my own groups. I have goals where I'd like to write for a major motion picture or write for some type of film, to continue this. Goals to be a much better saxophonist. So you have goals to have earnings for your band. I want to be able to pay my musicians a certain amount of money. I want them to be able to earn a certain amount of money in a year with me. So then I'll have the musicians consistent like I want them, if I'm able to

pay them, or keep them on enough of a basis where this money is coming along. But I do feel that you make that goal and you say well you know what, I'm going to learn a song a week for six months. So that's something basic. So the first week "There'll Never Be Another You." Then the next week "I'll Remember April." Then the next week "'Round Midnight." Then the next week – okay. And then once you memorize those songs, in six months, how many songs would you know. Or if you made a simple goal, I want to practice every day for one hour for six months, no matter what. Where would we be if we practiced every day for at least one hour, no matter what, for six months? You're going to be a lot stronger than you are today. And within that, then you make little goals. Well what am I going to practice? You know Branford told me Wynton Marsalis, his brother, would get up in the morning and put on his metronome at 60. So [sings] dah dah de dah, dah dah de dah etc. That's from Herbert Clarke Trumpet Studies. He practiced like that for six months. And one day he just woke up and [sings much faster] dah dah de dah etc. you know what I mean? So you've got to work towards — you've got to crawl, and you've got to walk, then you can run. You've got to make the baby steps. It's just like anything that you're doing, in terms of an educator or as a teacher, it started with a certain theme or thought process, now you have a skill set that you work from with respect to these interviews, how you go about it, the nature of it, the questions. It's all a skill set. And so what the student has to realize is that it's a skill set. And you have to figure, okay, what do I want to practice. And these are the things that I learned a little later, maybe I can share it with them, just so you don't waste a lot of time. You can figure out what you want to practice, how you want to practice, the amount of time. Sometimes I'm learning now when you mind tells you I should stop, you keep going, that's when you should stop. Just stop. If you've been practicing for three hours and your mind tells you to stop and you keep practicing, are you really still progressing or have you hit the wall? You've probably hit the wall. So the little things like that, but there's so many little subtle things that we can do. You know again, I read all these kind of what most people call corny books, you know like one book I read one time said every time the phone rings, smile before you answer it. I tried it a couple of times and I said wow, the conversation always seems to be pleasant.

MR: Well this has been a pleasant conversation.

JJ: Okay.

MR: I enjoyed it a lot.

JJ: My pleasure.

MR: Do you have any last Blakeyisms you want to share with us?

JJ: Well I tell you what, I feel that in Art's honor I want to try to help as many people as I can because I know that's what he was doing. He wanted to help musicians and I know

that one thing he always told me is don't put another musician down because if you put another musician down you're putting yourself down. So I try to, obviously in my recesses we make more judgments about people than we probably should, but I always feel that I should start off with something positive to say about any artist or any musician. Find something positive. Because there really is something there that's positive. We just choose to look at the negative aspect of it, but everyone doing something has some redeeming quality that we can find, and so I just want to be as helpful to other musicians as Art Blakey was to me, as Elvin was to me, as Freddie Hubbard was to me, Eddie Harris, Stanley Turrentine, all these guys were very available, and Sonny Rollins is available to me, Ron Carter. All these musicians, it's one big happy community. So I have to be willing to support other people in their endeavors in the way I was supported, and so that would be my Art Blakey — Art Blakey used to wear a tee shirt that said "Experience Teaches" and so I think if I can maybe give some advice and help someone to facilitate their career a little bit, quicker than I did, then that's my responsibility.

MR: All right. Well said. On that note, I'll get you to your next engagement. And thanks for your time.

JJ: Thank you.